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John Lamb

Bassist John Lamb was born in Vero Beach, Florida on December 4, 1933. His diverse path in life has included a stint in the Air Force, performing with Duke Ellington, teaching in public school, and a return to the jazz arena.

John was interviewed in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 16, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Clearwater Beach and I'm very pleased to have bassist John Lamb with me here today.

JL: Thank you.

MR: And I've been looking forward to talking to you for a couple of weeks now. You've kind of come full circle. You were born down here, weren't you?

JL: I was born in Vero Beach. Yes. I wasn't too proud of it at the time but—

MR: Why is that?

JL: Well it was a small town and nothing, as far as I was concerned, and it was in the middle of nowhere. Although it was like, I'm sure it was a small paradise because it was right there on the east coast where all the beautiful beaches were. But the attitudes were in a different direction at that time and that's why I didn't want to be from Vero Beach.

MR: Can you tell me about those attitudes?

JL: Those attitudes I discovered one day on television when I was in my twenties. So the television told me, it said hey, this is what happened to you when you were growing up in Vero Beach, or growing up in Fort Pierce, which was 15 or 16 miles a way, south of Vero Beach. But anyway I was born on a farm in Vero Beach. My mother used to work, used to be a domestic. And we played along with all kids, everybody had a great time, I grew up thinking that I was well adjusted and a fine young man, I felt good about myself you know and everything. And then later on, I would say I moved where I had to go to St. Augustine at age a year and a half or two, and then my father died at age, what about three, three and a half. Then I had, among relatives, all kinds of relatives, and they moved me back to Ft. Pierce. My mother was in Vero Beach and she used to come by once a week to see me and I lived there with them because they could better take care of me. And so I grew up in Ft. Pierce, another area that I stayed in until graduating from high school at age 16. I didn't realize it was a big deal at the time but most people graduated at 18. I didn't realize it but during that time you could graduate at age 16 and there was nothing else to do but study.

MR: There was no distractions.

JL: No distractions, right, sure. But I wasn't proud of the area, like I said, because of the attitudes among the people. I grew up feeling good, like I said, about myself. But I discovered one day watching the tube that there were different things going on as compared to other parts of the country as far as the working relationships, the social aspect of it, the equal rights so to speak part of it. Those are the things that I didn't feel good about later on.

MR: You found out that you had grown up in an area that —

JL: That wasn't too cool.

MR: —that wasn't too cool.

JL: That's right, sure. But I mean I felt good about it. I mean at the time, as a kid, if you're born in a situation and you don't know any differently, then it's okay, sure.

MR: And your friends were white and black.

JL: Yes. Sure. My employers were white, and I felt good about them. They were very nice to me. But there were other things that were out there that maybe I was unaware of at that time. My teachers were excellent. I loved my teachers so much that I wanted to become a teacher. And I felt that they did a very good job with what materials they had, and the way they worked, sure.

MR: After graduation, you had a career decision?

JL: Yeah I had to earn some money. So I went to the man that was raising me at the time, my uncle, and I said, "what would you do now that you're graduated from—" now that I'm graduated from high school. He says, "I'd go in the Army." You know at that time it was an option. And I found myself walking Eighth Street in Ft. Pierce and everything was beginning to become a little bit boring. So I said well it's time to do something different. So I went into the Air Force. I went down to Miami, I stayed 2 or 3 days for the induction part of it, and I had to wait. Actually I was 16 when I really applied. I had to wait until I was 17. And then when I turned 17, in December, they said okay, we'll induct you now with your mother's permission. So my mother signed me into the Air Force. Down while being in Miami, I ran into those social things. Because here we are in one building being tested for the military, and then we had a break for lunch and they says, "okay, everybody hop over across the street and get lunch." So I walked with the rest of the cats across the street to get lunch. I walked in there and everybody looked up at me as if I was from a different planet or something. And so I ignored it, and they ushered me back to the kitchen while my buddies ate. So it was sort of a time when nothing could be done about that.

MR: This was about 1950?

JL: Oh, it was December of '50, exactly. So I had my lunch and went back to the post office and continued to enroll into the military.

MR: And when you got in the military—

JL: Okay they put us on a train see? They put us on a train and you went out to — you know during those days blacks and whites had to ride in separate cars. But one thing I noticed on this particular coach, they put us all in the same coach. I said this is different, we are riding in the same coach. So anyway we went up through Alabama. We got to Alabama, it's time for another lunch break, right? So they says, "you have to get off the train and go across the street and get something to eat." So I walked right into the place there, and one of the guys says, "we can't serve that guy over there." And they says, "John, would you like me to bring you a sandwich or something?" So then we go out, and I says, "all right, that'll be fine." So back on the train, and we hopped on towards San Antonio. That's where the inductees were brought at that time. So two little incidents right there.

MR: And were you in uniform at that time?

JL: Not at that time, no. Not at that time. So we went through the training and all of that. And by the way, I was a tuba player.

MR: Oh, okay. Now we have to backtrack and we'll talk about the music, but this is very interesting.

JL: Okay, well I played the tuba and there was a warrant officer in there that heard me play, and my tone was very good, and I could play the chromatic scale and the B flat major scale and my reading was down a little bit. And he says, "your reading is not good but you have a very good tone." He says, "I'll give you six months to come up to par." So he gave me a break. His name was Proctor. Warrant Officer Proctor. Proctor used to be with the band in Lockburn, at Lockburn I believe. There was an all-black outfit and he eventually became a Warrant Officer and I just happened to run across him at this time and he gave me a break. Now after that little bit of training in San Antonio they moved us up to Montana.

MR: Oh boy.

JL: Great Falls, Montana. Could you imagine being there?

MR: From Florida. Whoa.

JL: So I hopped off the thing, the what do you call it, the train, and all this snow, and I'd never seen snow before. I was definitely curious. So they shuffled us on out to the air base. But after having been there at the air base for a while I began to become more involved in the music. They gave me six months, like I said, to come up to par, which I did, and sort of surpassed a few others that were there that had been there a few years that had become complacent you know. Then one day the first sergeant says, "we have a man on leave here, John, do you play bass?" I said, "sure, I play bass, no problem." So I went over and pretended that I—

MR: You didn't play bass.

JL: No I didn't really play bass. And he says, "yeah, go ahead and try it." His name was Earl Evans. He was a tech sergeant. He was somewhere, what's that, Nebraska or someplace now. And he says, "go ahead, try it." So I picked it up. He says, "you want to try it for a few days? I says, "yeah." So I took it up and I learned how to tune G D A and E, and because of my tuba experience I would play root and fifth, I learned what root and fifth were, the finger here and the finger there you know, that type of thing. So I did that for about two or three days, and I was good enough to play the gig that Friday night, playing my root and fifth, and like two-beat, that type of thing. And of course time made it a little better. And I began to make some kind of progress somewhere, and they offered me like a ten dollar job at the service club, or the NCO club or something like that. And they gave me my ten dollars, and I says this is pretty good. And the old bass player came back off leave in 30 days and they wanted me instead of him. Why? Because of my ability to feel the music and to feel the swing of it. And so this continued on, and I continued to practice. And then one day we had a group come in from out of town that played a little jazz for us. They didn't have a bass player. So I sat in with them and they encouraged me. And I later found out that they were living in Great Falls, that they were from in town. So they encouraged me to come in, so I did. I went in and took a bass there and sat in with them. But I later discovered that the place was off limits. So I had to sneak into the club and when the policemen came in I would have to get on the bandstand and play. And so I did that for a long time, maybe a couple of years, getting all this experience.

MR: Did you have to be in uniform when you'd go into town like that?

JL: No.

MR: Okay. Because otherwise you'd be like — you'd really stick out in there.

JL: They could tell by my shoes, they looked at my shoes. Everybody wore black shoes in the Air Force you know.

MR: Interesting. What would the, can you recall, at one of those very first gigs you played as a bass player, what were some of the songs that you would have played at the time?

JL: You mean with that Air Force group?

MR: Yeah.

JL: Let's see. We were into Stan Kenton.

MR: No kidding?

JL: Yeah, I heard a lot of Kenton at that time because the guys would bring their records. And I didn't listen to jazz or anything like that. I remember "Apple Honey." [scats] Was that Woody Herman's?

MR: Yeah. "Autumn —"

JL: Yeah, Autumn something. [scats] The saxophones. It was a saxophone thing. And I learned the parts to that by learning to read the parts.

MR: Okay. So you had some music.

JL: Yeah.

MR: All right.

JL: And then I listened to a lot of people in town there and the influences were, I heard guys bring in recordings of Stitt & Ammons, I heard a recording of Fats Navarro. I heard a lot of Kenton and a lot of big bands. And then I heard this bass player called Safranski. Ed Safranski. And what I did I said hey that's pretty good, everybody seems to like it. Because he would feature certain people in certain sections. And so I learned Safranski's bass part and that taught me some scales. I had to dig for some positions. They weren't necessarily correct positions, but I learned the scales from having played tuba. And I went to town to see if I could find a book and I did find a book, and it was Bobby Haggart's book. He had pictures on there. Later on down here I told him about that. And I think he got a kick out of it. He said that was the best book that was ever written for bass, that was his saying. But anyway Bobby Haggart had some influence there through his method. And then some people would come through town, I remember a guy's name was Gene, that's all I remember, blonde, had a beard, had a space in the front, and I went over to his hotel room and I wanted to get a lesson or two. "What do you want to know?" I didn't know what I wanted to know, I just wanted, you know. And that was it. So little experiences like that. But up there in Montana I got the chance to work with some of the musicians there and there was one fellow by the name of Rudy Williams, he played sax, tenor. He says, "you know what? You sound like my cousin." I said, "who's your cousin? He says, "Charles Mingus." I had never heard of Mingus you know. That's what he said. And what was I to know? I'm just a kid that's playing a bass. And then one night on the jukebox, while playing in the same joint, I heard something coming out of the box, a trio. I didn't really know what the combination was, but it was something. I said to one of the guys in the band, I said, "who is that playing bass?" And he said, "that's Ray Brown." I said hmmm, so I began to edge closer to the jukebox. And I listened to this and I said it sounds good, a nice tone and it sounds almost like a tuba. And then Oscar Peterson was on piano and Herb Ellis I believe or either Barney—

MR: Barney Kessel.

JL: Yeah Barney Kessel. Later in life I worked with both of those guys.

MR: That's great.

JL: And then I met Ray and Oscar and all those, we did gigs together. Well anyway I began to investigate Ray Brown, like when I went on leave I heard some of his things coming out of a jukebox in Savannah, the trio playing. And I said that's Oscar, huh? And then I began to investigate Charlie Parker and I used to listen to that because guys would bring

their music in and I'd listen and listen and listen. I don't know if I was really learning anything but it was part of my consciousness now.

MR: Wow. What was your actual job in the service?

JL: My job was a tuba player.

MR: So you got through the service as a tuba player?

JL: As a tuba player, yes.

MR: You played for the marches.

JL: Yes, everything.

MR: You played the sousaphone also?

JL: Yeah, sousaphone, yeah. And I did that for about, that hitch for about three years. And I learned a lot from other musicians and the method books and observing what they were doing and so on. But I'll tell you another experience I had one day in the latrine. We had to go through Basic again because we hadn't completed Basic in Texas. So we had to go through that again. And one day I was in the latrine practicing the tuba. So one of the guys, a staff sergeant walks in and says, "you think you're so damn smart, what are you practicing for?" Well I'm trying to figure out where does this come from? "What are you practicing so much for?" And I was just practicing and practicing. It turns out that I think he was very drunk, he had been drinking and when he got to that stage he went a little bit crazy. I later on met him too and I confronted him with that in Vero Beach.

MR: In Vero Beach.

JL: Yeah. But I did it in such a nice way, the man had changed completely, he was a different person. He had had some problems in his childhood that reflected in his daily living so I understand that. No problem. But anyway this experience lasted for about three years, this military experience. And I became — got out. But just before getting out I met a fellow by the name of Oscar Tunnard. Oscar was supposed to be one of these brainy guys that could remember everything. He played that way. He was from St. Petersburg originally. And what is he doing up in Montana? But anyway I met him in Montana. And he used to talk about a place called the Schillinger House. It's the old — well it's Berklee now. It's Berklee School of Music. And it used to be the Schillinger House because Schillinger used to, that's where—

MR: The Schillinger Method.

JL: Quincy Jones went there. But anyway he talked about that and he says if he had his choices he would go to Berklee, or to Schillinger House. So somehow that stayed in my head. I said well I think I'll go up and try it. And so after we were discharged and working with this monster pianist for six months I decided to give that a shot. But prior to leaving the military again, I was talking to this piano player Oscar about Ray Brown. I says, "you know this Ray Brown guy?" And of course we'd been listening to Shearing

and all that and Oscar, those were the two major pianists at the time. He says, "yeah, I've heard of Ray Brown." And he says, "there's a guy down in Miami can do everything Ray can do." I says, "who is that?" He says, "Sam Jones." I didn't know who Sam Jones was. I'd never heard of him. And later on he was working with Cannonball and quite a few others. And I met him later on in my career, yeah. Anyway I get out of the military and decide that I'd try to go back to Vero Beach. I went to Vero Beach and got a job at a packing house, you know, to make some money. And there wasn't anything going on there. I mean everything was domestic, I tried cleaning and I wondered if I could work in a hospital as an orderly or something. And it didn't turn out too well. I think I stayed in the packing house a little over a week or two weeks, and I had $27 saved up. I didn't even get along with my parents, my mother at that time, because I had changed. You know when you're in your early twenties it's very difficult to get along with parents at that age, because I knew quite a bit. She says, "well what you should do, John," she says, "is take this job until you can find something else." But there was nothing else better in Vero Beach. Have you been to Vero Beach?

MR: No.

JL: Well it's a lot different today.

MR: I think so.

JL: But it had about 16,000 people at the time. And it was a very small town. So I decided to take my $27, I said, "well I'm going to Boston to Schillinger House." I didn't have any money or anything like that. So I said, "I'm heading for Schillinger House." So I hopped on the bus—

MR: Is that right?

JL: Yeah, I hopped on the bus, moved on up, and I think it was two or three days to New York. When we got there for a break the porter outside says, "where are you going?" I says, "I'm going to Boston." He says, "what do you do?" "I'm a musician." He said, "what are you going up there for? Everything is right here." He says, "you'll be back."

MR: This is in New York?

JL: Yeah. We're taking a little break there, yeah. Yeah, "you'll be back." I said, "okay," so I hopped on and went to Boston. Because I knew I had met somebody that was originally from Vero Beach by the name of Henderson and he says, "well come on up we'll help you out." So I went up there and I found out he was a Pullman porter. So they put me up in the Pullman porter's place for, what, seven dollars a week. So he gave me a room and I tried to wait tables. I remember the first job I ever tried to do up there and the guy says, "you've got to have a tux." I had a black suit, double breasted. It looked good, a nice, black suit. I went on and he gave me a table and all that, and he gave me a tray. I had never done this stuff. And he said, "this is your table, by the way, is that a tux you have

on? That's not a tux. Out." So I was out. So anyway I ended up getting a job at Steuben's Restaurant in Boston as a dishwasher. And I washed a few pots and pans. And I think that lasted a little over a week too. But in the meantime I went back to the Schillinger House and asked for my application fee back. I think it was like $25 or something.

MR: You asked for it back?

JL: Yeah. He says, "we don't normally do this." Probably the dean. But he says, "we understand your situation." This is where Herb Pomeroy and all those people taught, and John LaPorta and all, they teach up there. And he says, "we don't normally do this but we understand your situation" so they gave me the money back. And I took the money and applied it toward my room.

MR: Did you decide not to go there because you just couldn't afford it?

JL: Well I couldn't go there, no money. But while I was getting my money back, I heard this beautiful bass sound coming out of the room. Somebody was bowing this instrument. I said oh that's so beautiful, I didn't realize that a bass could sound like that. And all of this sound was filtering out. I don't have any idea to this day who that was. But it stayed with me. And while washing these dishes, these pots, there was a group out in the lobby playing. And I looked out there and the guys all had tuxes you know, looking good. And of course I had a little musical background and I said that's what I'd like to do, you know, play out there in the lounge. I shouldn't be back here in washing these pots. So it turns out it was Joe Bruno's father that was playing in that group. And Joe Bruno I met 20 years later, or much later, down in Sarasota. And I also met his son, so I met the father when I was in the kitchen, but not formally but through his music. And then I met the son later on down in Sarasota, and then his other son, his son, who plays bass. So we have three Brunos. But anyway after that little experience I got a job playing in another club, in Eddie Levine's place on the corner of Mass and Columbus in Boston. And they said hmmm, they gave me an audition and all that. So I played my Ed Safranski solo.

MR: All right.

JL: They had a little quartet you know, I mean that's all I knew. And I'd walk a little time, and I had my Chubby Jackson model five string bass.

MR: Oh you did. I'll be darned. That's right he had his own little.

JL: Yeah, he had this five string bass. But you know later on I discovered that Slam Stewart tuned his bass with a high C on top. And I didn't realize that at the time. And then in that little corner we had the Hi-Hat, we had all the jazz cats come over there. Are you familiar with Boston? Mass Columbus? We had that little corner, we had Wally's across the street where I met Pops Foster. Pops Foster was 75 about that time and he was claimed to be the first guy to begin plucking the bass. And I said, "Pops, come on over, I want you to catch my act and see how I do on the bass." So he came out and checked out my sound

and he says, "good sound." And you know, encouragement. And in this little joint, Eddie Levine's, I met all kinds of musicians, they used to come up and visit our leader, who was Dean Earl. And as far as my style and being a gentleman and being in the business and all that, was a fellow by the name of, like I said, his name was Dean Earl. And he talked about good manners and musicianship and personality, being on and off the stand, and not drinking excessively. He says, "if you're going to drink, always have a good meal first." You know, that type of thing. And so he was like a mentor. And so Dean was also a graduate of Berklee. He also taught there and all those things. And he advised me as far as schools are concerned. He says, "if I were you," he says, "I would go to a different school." He says, "Berklee doesn't offer you a teaching degree." So I thought about it, so I went over to the New England Conservatory and I hang around the practice room a little bit, just getting the feel of things and all that. And in the meantime at the Hi-Hat across the street, I used to hear all of these groups come in, all these small groups. Guys like Shadow Wilson and Miles Davis and Ella Fitzgerald and Hot Lips Page, and all those kind of people. And then there was another place called The Shell Bone, not The Shell Bone, there was a famous club in New Orleans at one time, there was another club in Boston, George Wein—

MR: Oh yes, Storyville.

JL: Storyville. George Wein owned that. And the big man in town was Jimmy Woode, the bass player, and Junior Raglin, whenever Duke would come to town would come by and sit and play. And I'd listen to these guys and I'm beginning to pick up on what they — I says now what's so appealing about that? I says I can do that. And so on. And got a chance to hear Basie over at Storyville and I heard Duke and I heard Charlie Parker and Prez along with Duke's band, and the singers, Joe Williams, and that thing "Every Day" that they put out.

MR: "Every Day I Have the Blues."

JL: Yes. I used to go up to the jukebox late at night and listen to that all the time, listen to that bass player, Ed Jones. Remember Ed Jones?

MR: Yeah.

JL: And I listened to that kind of things. And in the meantime I had a gig after hours right across the street there, what was it called, I don't know but anyway it was a little after-hours joint. We played from maybe two to five in the morning. You know, I mean that type of thing. And one night Billie Holiday walks in. And she sits down on the side there with her little dog, a Chihuahua I think it was. And so put my hand out like this, and the dog grabbed me. She says, "honey don't do that," she says, "always do like this." You know like put your hand out like that. She says, "he won't bite you then." She kept her little dog in her purse. And she sang one or two tunes with us that night. Just an informal

thing. It was during the Boston years. And the Boston thing just went on for a while and then my night gig ran out after a year. But I was making $50 a week. And all the other guys says, "well that's a poor paying club" they says, "the guy didn't pay you too much money." But to me—

MR: Fifty bucks.

JL: Was fifty dollars. And I know I ate a lot of sardines and I ate a lot of, what do they call those things, peanuts and Coke. I ate a lot of those.

MR: To fill you up.

JL: And I would sleep late in the afternoon so I wouldn't use up so much energy. That type of thing.

MR: Man, you were paying some dues I guess.

JL: I think I lost about, at that time I lost about ten or fifteen pounds. Of course today that would be great. But anyway that went on for a while and then I says I have to do something about this. I says it's time for me to make a change. Because I've heard other people talking about that they needed a trade, and they were tired of going from one gig to the other and so on. But during this time in Boston, I got one good gig, I think I had a week with Ella. She was coming through Boston, or was in Boston already and they needed a bass player for Philadelphia. So I went down to the station with my bass. I was supposed to meet them. And I looked around and I didn't see anybody, no Ella, no anybody. You know I'm just a kid, nobody. And so I says well maybe I should just hop on the train and I'll see them at the next station or somewhere. So what I did, I don't know why I did this, but I put my bass in the baggage room and left it there and I stayed on the train and sure enough there they were, waiting at the platform looking for me. "I wonder where the kid is." There was Marcus Foss, the drummer who called me Junior, that type of thing. And Don Abney who was the piano player, and all these guys were well seasoned. And so Ella says, "oh there he is," she says, "where's your bass honey?" I said it's at the station and then I tried to explain it and I couldn't explain it. So that upset her quite a bit. And she says, "honey, always keep your bass with you." She says, "Ray always took his bass with him wherever he went." Because she used to be married to Ray. And so we hopped on the train to go to Philly. But my mentor, Dean, told me he says, "always keep a diamond on your finger, so whenever you have a problem you'll be able to eat anyway."

MR: So you could pawn it?

JL: So I had a little diamond ring that I had bought, because I was following my mentor see? Which was excellent advice. So I went to the music store and they had an old bass in the corner and I says, "well look man," I said, "I'm working down here at Pep's, and all I have is my ring, can I use your bass for a couple of days?" So he looked at the ring, he

says, "yeah, okay." So he loaned me this bass, he asked me who was I working with. I told him Ella Fitzgerald, that type of thing, and so I took the bass and went down and worked with her a few days. Then in the meantime we sent for my other bass. And so it arrived, my Chubby Jackson model. And so I took it back. That's how that happened, one week with Ella.

MR: Yeah I bet the bass from the pawn shop didn't have five strings on it.

JL: Well actually no. It didn't. Actually it wasn't a pawn shop, it was a music store.

MR: Oh, okay.

JL: All the musicians used to go in there. As a matter of fact I bought my Ray Brown method book from there. Sure.

MR: So you entered into your Philadelphia kind of time from there is that right?

JL: Yeah. Well no, that's another story. That's another story. A week in Philadelphia and then I went to Atlantic City for a while, and then there was no more work. I says now what's happening. I began to assess myself and I said well what's happening. I says you do have a skill, you can play the tuba, you had a military career, well three or four years anyway, and I says you're young and all those kinds of things. I says it's time for you to do something. I hit rock bottom there as far as employment goes. And I'd see all these prosperous looking people and I says there's nothing out here that I know how to do. What can I do? But there for a short time I did get a job in a haberdashery for about six months. And that had me going for a while. I substituted for a saxophone player. So between those two gigs, working a little bit at nights and the haberdashery, I was able to make it. But after that everything was — you know, because I had to live from day to day. So I decided, I says well I think I'll go back into the Air Force. So finally that was my decision. I went back in the Air Force and I went back in this time with one stripe. Before I had no stripes. But I had one stripe. I went into the band, the guys had heard that I had worked a week with Ella or had worked with a few musicians around Boston you know, and I had a little prestige there.

MR: You came with a reputation.

JL: Yeah, and had a little tuba experience because I had done that before. So I was a little bit ahead of the game. But I said I have to really do something about my abilities. I says, I decided right there and then that I was going to become the world's greatest bass player. I decided, that's what I put into my head. I says you have to do it. I don't know why, I think I was sort of like driven and I had experienced hunger, and I experienced the disappointments and all those kind of things. And I had a craving or a love, and then all these social things that I experienced before were coming through. You know what I mean? From what I experienced as a child. I didn't know what they were, but I had to express all of this in some way, otherwise it would have come out in the form of pimples

you know what I mean? Anyway, I went back in the Air Force and I did this thing, and within six months I had an awakening. I mean really. I hit a low one day and then I had to go through these changes. I don't know, it's mental, physical, and it's like an awareness came over me. I began to investigate spirituality a little bit. Psychology. All the books that I could read on the subjects that were on the base library I began to investigate. And I got rid of all my jazz records. And I had a whole slew of, I just tossed all of that aside. And while this was happening, going through this change, one of the guys came into the barracks one day and says, "John," he says, "I found you a bass teacher." As if like, you know, he just came out of nowhere. The guy used to play with the Cleveland Orchestra. His name was Tad Shetler. He played with them for about, well quite a number of years, over ten years, had to be. And he was also a pianist, a concert pianist. And after we got to meet each other I found out that he couldn't get a job playing concert piano so he went to bass. And he had studied with the premier, the first chair of Boston. So in a sense I had gotten my teacher indirectly through him. And Mr. Shetler, I stayed with him for a couple of years, two or three years and learned what I could. Talk about — an awful sound I got out of the instrument, it was terrible. That Kay bass, it was terrible. Scratchy — didn't know anything about bows or anything. And he taught me out of the Simandl Book, Franz Simandl. That's the so-called bass Bible. And we worked with that and I scratched my way through it for about two or three years. And then somebody came up to me and said, "John, you want to go overseas? There's an opening in Iceland."

MR: Oh jeez.

JL: I says, "yeah, sign me up." I wanted to get out of Roswell, New Mexico. That's where we were. We were in Roswell, New Mexico.

MR: Man I'll tell you, you've been to some of the hot spots.

JL: Oh definitely. That's where they have the UFO sightings or something. And by the way in Roswell I had some experiences too, like social things. Like they had a sign up on the wall that says, "we refuse the right to serve anyone." I mean I was a GI, you know, off base there trying to have a little fun with my buddies and that was on the wall. And the same thing happened in Montana by the way. That's almost, that's not too far from the border you know. So in each place I had a little touch of that social problem.

MR: Did that attitude also include your fellow military people?

JL: If it did I didn't notice it too much. I don't know why I didn't pay too much attention, it was just something I just didn't notice. I guess I was lucky that way. Not unless I had a direct confrontation. If I had a direct confrontation then I would sort of listen to it and ignore it somehow. I don't know why but it just went on. It came out in the music I guess. Because now that you ask that question I did have an experience with a guy that I went on leave with once. He was a bagpipe player up in Montana. And we were going along

and he was from Tennessee. And he said, "do you know what a nigger is?" That type of thing. And I just sort of dismissed it. Boom. Gone. That's the only direct thing that I can recall during that time. But back to Roswell, they said, "well Iceland, we could ship you up there." And then they found out that I was black and they says, "we don't have any black GI's up there." So I couldn't go to Iceland. So instead I chose Shreveport, Louisiana, which was just as bad. So I went to Shreveport and everybody was fine on base. The problem was off-base because the city ordinances, yeah. Whites and blacks couldn't sit on the same row, in the front together or in the back together. One had to be in the back, if he was going to work you know what I mean. And I had another thing that happened there, while I was in this spirituality thing. I had a fellow that used to come up to the air base once a week, because I couldn't go, and be with the group, because of the laws. And they are all white see? But anyway he would come out to the base, and he was a captain and I was a little, whatever it was, two or three stripes. And he's walk in the barracks and everybody would snap to. And he'd say, "hey John, how are you?" Yeah. That type of thing. Because he was there to help me with my — we'd find some place, a corner or somewhere, and we'd talk, or a building. And we'd talk about spiritual things. And he did that for as long as I was there at the air base.

MR: And when you were in Louisiana, what year was this?

JL: I think '58, '59, '58. But on the air base everything was fine. There were quite a few officers that played instruments that had love for the music. And because I had my little prestige thing going they all wanted to come over and play with me. So we had that kind of relationship. There was no segregation as far as officers and enlisted men. And every time one of these guys would walk into the barracks or they came to see me, guys would snap up, and they said oh, John, meet so-and-so and let's make this gig. You know what I mean? And that was the end of that. And while were we in Shreveport, like I said, this guy used to come out once a week and talk to me. After that, during that period they had a general conference of all the spiritual people getting together in this big auditorium in town. And I was a part of the group. "John, we'd like to have you come but there's nothing we can do to get around this law." So they says, "we have a solution. You comply with the law, you sit up there in the balcony," and there were about five or six other people out there in the main auditorium there, and of course I was used to balconies, you know the movie theatres and that type of thing. So I was used to balconies. And so I put on my uniform, full dress you know, because I wanted to have this experience just to see. So I went through that experience and here was the representative to the main office talking to this spiritual group. And so the meeting is over and he came over and shook my hand and that was the end of that. So later on in the band thing, the

military part — this is unrelated to the meeting — they said, "John, we have an opening for you to ship out someplace if you want." "Where is this?" "Newfoundland."

MR: Newfoundland?

JL: Newfoundland. Ernest Harmon Air Force Base. That's where all the military planes used to go through — not all of them but a great deal of them — used to go through during the days when they had props, these four-engine jobs. Elvis Presley came through there and stopped over.

MR: A refueling stop?

JL: Yeah, and a few others. So I said okay. I went up to the Ernest Harmon Air Force Base and stayed two years, drifts were as high as this ceiling. Eight foot drifts, you know what I mean? And I had a chance to practice. You couldn't go outside, so I practiced.

MR: Yeah, no distractions, right?

JL: Yeah. Now one thing about all three duties, all these duties that I mentioned, Montana, the social life was poor, so I practiced. Three years. Went out and played for a year or so, a couple of years, came back into New Mexico found a teacher and I practiced eight to ten hours a day. Now what could you do? And then I continued this process on and on, remembering that you have a goal to become the world's greatest bass player. So I practiced, practiced. I'd go and have breakfast, 7 o'clock in the morning, go back as if it were a job, practice until about noon, go back and have lunch, then practice all afternoon unless we had a special rehearsal or we had to play the flag down. Then I might go to the movies for a couple of hours at 6 'til about 7:30 or 8, then come back and practice for a couple of hours until about 10 o'clock at night, and then go to the barracks at night, then start the process over the next day. And that's the way that happened. And Great Falls — did I say Great Falls — Newfoundland was no different. They had social problems up there. They had private clubs. And unless you were a member of the club you couldn't get in. And you know, no members were black members. So it was sort of like a subtle thing. But one on one, one on one I found that 99 or 98 percent of the people that I've met have always been nice people. It's just that the laws were in such a state that it influenced thinking. And some people had grown up with the mentality that they were in some ways superior because, in some ways. But I knew differently. I still know differently. There is no such thing, it's just an individual matter, it's just who you are as a person. And maybe that's always what I sense about individuals, and somehow whenever they said or did something that was disturbing, somehow it would just sort of go away. It didn't bother me. I don't know why.

MR: Was there ever a conflict between your choice of jazz oriented music and your spirituality? Was there any kind of — these don't work together for you?

JL: Well as a kid I'd heard that the blues and rhythm was the devil's music. And I didn't really listen to the blues that much. I heard it, because it was a part of the scene. Getting back to that high school thing, I remember hearing Louis Jordan swing on the jukebox, singing "Caldonia" and all those things, and I'd see them in movies and I heard Tommy Dorsey's [scats] and he'd play that long trombone solo on it, which was very nice. And I loved those things. They were all based on the blues. And of course the church was in there too, I used to go to church all the time and I'd hear them sing. And I knew that there was a difference between the church and the school, it didn't seem real. It seemed to me like church was unrealistic as compared to what I experienced everyday in school. It seems like some kind of pie in the sky thing. Because he always preached the same sermons and it was always hell and — what do you call it? Hell and brimstone or something.

MR: Fire and brimstone, yeah.

JL: You know unless you come up and give me your hand and do such a thing, he says, you're going to die and go to hell in a minute. So and what about that? My buddies, speaking about that hell and brimstone thing, my buddies you know, we were all about nine or ten years old. They were a little bit older than I was. So I saw them go up and get the preacher's hand one day. And they says well it's very nice that these young men have joined the church. So I didn't want to be outdone by my buddies so I went up there and gave the preacher my hand. And he asked me some questions and I turned my head and whispered, the low part of my voice, and he would translate to the audience and, "well that's very fine." So we were all baptized and I was with my buddies again. And that's how that part of it started, that church thing. And that's all there was to do.

MR: Well tell me about, in Philadelphia you had some of your own band-leading experiences, didn't you? Did you lead some of your own groups eventually?

JL: Well I led a group in the Air Force as well. And I had a trio around Philadelphia and I worked with Jimmy Heath and Specs Wright and Sam Dochre and Kenny Barron. Did I tell you I met Kenny Barron? I saw a bass player going into the subway one day. And I says, "hey, where are you going?" He says, "I'm going to a session." I says, "you mind if I follow you?" So he says, "no, come on." So I followed him around and he went over this guy's house, the guy was playing piano. It was Kenny Barron. It was Kenny's house. And later on I discovered that Kenny worked with Heath, Jimmy Heath on the weekends. And that's how that relationship began. And I met a lot of musicians that were on the corner that played. I met Ray Gullin in Boston and worked with him for six months. I met the chief arranger for the Air Force band in DC, we worked together for a while. And now these were all very, very, very talented people, very smart and very hard working people. And there was something about them, some qualities about them that I liked.

They had those abilities to do these things. But I discovered that it was more work than just being smart. It was a lot of work. A lot of work. Effort. And a lot of things that I didn't necessarily want to hear, like I said, musically. I had to go through all of that in order to reach the type of sound that I wanted to reach.

MR: How was the pop music scene at the time? You had rock & roll really making a big impact, you know, with Elvis and all those guys. Did that affect—

JL: Yeah, I didn't like Elvis. No. I says he's a musician, I'm a musician, I says, his music doesn't sound as good as mine. But he had that gyration going. Those knees going. So it's show biz, you know, playing guitar. I didn't care for country music. But strangely enough, as a kid I used to hear it every Saturday night on Grand Ole Opry. And there was one guy that I liked whose name was Grandpa Jones. The reason why I liked Grandpa Jones was because he used to talk about "that good old mountain dew." And I loved the lyrics to that. And I used to just wait around and be a few minutes late for school just to hear that. Yeah. Grandpa Jones. But the rest of the country music I didn't care for. But later on I discovered that it was like a cousin to jazz you know. And I also discovered that there were some very fine musicians involved in country music. And when I hear them in person I get more out of a kick watching them in person than I do listening. And then the lyrics are so simple and so down to earth and so basic that in a lot of cases they're worth listening to.

MR: So, when did you decide that again you needed to exit from the Air Force?

JL: About four or five years later. Five years later. I exited the Air Force and then went to Philly. And I was married to my wife, who I've been married to for about 40 years, the same woman, huh?

MR: Yeah. Great.

JL: Yeah. It's amazing. She is the one that encouraged the musical thing. She says, "you might be sorry someday if you don't do that." And it took a lot on her part to do that.

MR: Yeah, sure. Especially when you start doing road work.

JL: Well the rock & roll scene came along, but I also owned an electric bass. I had gained one of those back in the Air Force days in the early 50s because Monk Montgomery used to play one, and one of the guys in the barracks was talking about he heard the bass and didn't see a bass anywhere. And it turned out to be — this was with Lionel Hampton's band.

MR: Oh, right.

JL: The rock scene, everybody seemed to have been going toward that thing, that direction, so I pulled out my electric bass and played a few things, whatever they wanted me to play. It was like a cousin to me. It was like a hobby. I never took it seriously, although I've been playing electric bass since 1958. Like for shows, that type of thing, I always

pulled it out. Like the horse shows, the ice shows, that type of thing. Because you have to read. It's like reading a book. You've done those shows, right?

MR: Um hum.

JL: And you just read it off and that's it. I didn't care too much, like I said, for the rock music because it was based on the blues, it was very simplistic [scats]. I said what is that? That's nothing. But now it's much better because you have better musicians playing it. More creativity and people that know something about music that have put their input, their compositional skills into rock and it sounds better. Sure. So I stayed with my four to the bar. And it seemed as if I've gotten more requests for that than anything else. One day I was in Philadelphia, I'd gone to college there at the University of the Performing Arts, at that time it was called the Philadelphia Musical Academy. At that school that's where Andre Watts used to attend and a few other people that reached a high level in music. I went there for a year and a half. And every Thursday they would have somebody perform, like pianists. So they asked me to come up and perform when I was new in the school. So I went and played my Ray Brown solo. And it was the first time they had heard something like that during that time.

MR: Really. This is supposedly a classical institution? Is that right?

JL: It was all classical, yes. It was called the Philadelphia Musical Academy. Before that it was affiliated with the Conservatory.

MR: Is it called the Curtis Institute now?

JL: Well no, Curtis is different.

MR: Curtis is something different.

JL: But we all had the same teachers, you know they'd go from one place to the next you know. And then we had Combs College of Music, they were all the same teachers. So I went and played my bass, my Ray Brown solo. Then after about a year and a half I began to have a — get a job at Acme Markets, a food chain, worked in the main office as a mail boy. I had a kid and a wife and they paid me $48 a week. So I was working gigs at night, in Read — not Reading.

MR: Reading.

JL: Yes, Reading. And all around the area, the Cherry Hill area, the Philadelphia area, just working gigs. And one day I came home after a long day and I saw this telegram. I opened it up and it says: "Opportunity if interested give me a call." So I, you know, just laid it on the table. And I think a few days later I called and it was a woman that answered the phone who happened to be a member of a very prominent family in New Jersey. As a matter of fact at one time he was Attorney General. His name was Walter Reed. And it was his wife, Mrs. Reed, had written the telegram, and she said, "I have this thing, I'm a friend of Duke Ellington's and maybe we could set you up with some kind of

contact there. All you have to do is come over to the house and we'll have a little party and we'll have some Cornish hen, bring your family and your kids and all that and I'll invite a few other people and I'm going to invite some musicians to play along with you." And in the back of my mind I said she wants some free music for her party. And so this went along and we set up a date and I piled my son in the back of the station wagon and my wife, and the bass and we went over to Riverton, New Jersey, which is across the river from Philly. And we played and she stuck a tape recorder down there. I was aware that the tape recorder was there so what I decided to do I decided to play in the style of Jimmy Blanton. So I was playing in the style of Jimmy Blanton, you know that very basic, driving beat. And so a few weeks later she shoved it in front of Duke when he came, he came to the Steel Pier. And then somehow through all of this bad recording you heard these notes coming out. And speaking of Jimmy Blanton, I heard about him when I was in Great Falls, Montana. Some guy was coming through with a band and he says, "have you heard of Jimmy Blanton?" I says, "no." He said, "well let me write you out one of his famous solos called 'Jack the Bear.'" So he wrote it out for me and he played it for me. So I learned it, and I went down into the store in Montana and I bought the record and learned it. And years later I met the same guy in San Francisco, I was on the road with Duke later on. That's interesting how they all came back. But she played this thing for Duke and Duke heard it. And one day I was sitting — I was living in a housing project by then, a housing project. And I was comfortable, my kids walking around. I got this phone call: "good evening, Mr. Lamb?" "Yes." "This is Duke Ellington." I said, "who?" "Duke Ellington." I said, "just a moment please." So I went back in there and told my wife, "that's Duke Ellington on the phone." I walked back. She was very cool about that. So I walked back in and I says, "yes, what can I do for you, Mr. Ellington?" And he says, "well look here, Mr. Lamb, we'd like you to come up to New York and play some things with us." So okay, fine. We set up a date. He said, "well we're up at a place called Freedom Land, why don't you try coming up there" — like say Tuesday or so. "Fine." "Bye." That was it. So I hopped on the train at North Station in Philly. Took my bass. This was before we had the wheel, and I carried it. Hopped on the train, went up to New York, got off the train, this was all on a Tuesday. Got off the train and got on another train and went up to the Bronx, and we ran out of subway. And so I had to take a taxi from there. So I took a taxi on over to Freedom Land, which at that time was sort of like a resort area or an entertainment place. And I walked in the place back there, back to the tents. I saw this guy walking around with his slippers on and I said that looks like Johnny Hodges. I'd seen his pictures you know. And I walked back through there and I says, "where's the band" I asked the guy. He says, "oh back there." So I went back into the tent, walked in and there was this guy sitting up with his blue outfit on, he had this

blue bandana around his head. And the television was blasting, blaring, it was distorted, I mean it was so loud. And he was fixed on that television set. Turns out that it was Duke. And I was approached by the band boy and he says, "are you here, the new bass player?" I said, "yeah." And he says, "hey Duke, the bass player's here." And Duke stands up and he walks, very gracious, a very nice man. He was like a perfect six feet, a perfect mannequin so to speak, you know, so graceful. Even in that outfit that he had on. And he was very soft spoken and as a matter of fact I says hmmm I'm in the presence of something here, but I don't know what it is. And he told me he says, "well yeah," he says, "you want to take the next set? The second half of the show?" "Yeah." He said, "okay." Then the band boy says, "can he read?" "Yeah, I can read." You know. So I went on up and did — Peg Morrison was the bass player at the time, he was there for a short time. And so I went in and played the second show. The first tune we did was "Stomping at the Savoy." I saw this blur, you know, he was kicking off the tune and I didn't — most band leaders will do something like this you know. I didn't see none of that, he just did like that and the band started. I says uh oh, this is a train. So I hopped on the train and we didn't quit until the end. It was in the key of D flat. "Stomping at the Savoy." Okay, the next tune I did was one of the tunes from his "Far East Suite," he had written that. And I looked at the music and I says this is written in fourths, I says that's going to be very muddy, I can't play that that low, with a low A on the bottom. So I reversed everything and made it like this. And somebody says he had noticed that I was changing Duke's music for the notes. He said, "what's he doing?" So I changed the music around and played, it was a bass solo in the very beginning. As a matter of fact that same thing was recorded afterwards and it received an award. So we played that Far East thing and Cootie says, "uh huh, that's all." Because everybody shook their head. So that was the end of that and the bass player came back out.

MR: Talk about trial by fire.

JL: Yeah, that's what it was. So I went in and did that and went on back to Philly. The next day another bass player was supposed to come by. But what happened, somebody was supposed to pick him up and the person didn't pick him up. And he didn't get the gig of course, he never showed up. He was depending upon somebody's word, whereas I took the train and lugged that thing up there and that probably made the difference. And the ability to play the bass notes. That's all it is is playing the bottom, whatever is required. And shortly after that I got another phone call back in Philly, it was from Mercer. Mercer says, "hey John, Pop wants you to come up to New York" on like Monday or so in a couple of weeks. Well I had to quit my job, you know, I had a day job. And so I said, "okay I'll arrange that." The first gig was with Mercer, with his band. He had picked up some guys in New York, all the New York musicians, including Grant Green the guitar

player and a whole lot of others. And Duke came in the next night and we began at Basin Street East and stayed for two or three weeks, then went on the road for a while. That's part of the story.

MR: Yeah. Interesting. This was 1964?

JL: Yeah, '64, right. 1964.

MR: What kind of salary did he offer you?

JL: Well my being naïve about salaries, anything was better than what I was getting, $48 a week, and so they decided to start me off with scale. They had to pay me the scale. It was about $60 or something a night I guess.

MR: I'm sorry, $60 a night?

JL: Yeah probably $60 a job or something like that. And the stars were getting all the money. And my being, not knowing anything about charges and all that, and prices, I was just happy to get a gig. I had been making $48 a week at Acme Markets. So $60 a night was great, huh? And compared to $50 a week at that other place years ago. And so I worked my way up. Gradually it began to increase.

MR: Yeah. And you were responsible for your own, putting yourself up?

JL: Yeah.

MR: The whole thing.

JL: Yeah, I was responsible for that. But I began to pull my way up a little bit gradually financially. And my wife, being the type of person that she is, utilized the monies in a very positive way. When I went overseas — as a matter of fact I didn't like the band at all. I didn't like the way they did their business. Everything seemed so unorganized.

MR: I had heard something about that.

JL: Yeah.

MR: That getting everybody on the stand sometimes was just a chore.

JL: That's right.

MR: And I mean not everybody had the same attitude you did about professionalism.

JL: Well I had been in the military. I was taught to be on time. Everybody else came in little by little. It didn't matter. They'd done it 40 or 50 years. They had the gig anyway. But Duke would come up and begin to play the piano [scats]. He'd do that for about ten minutes or so, and then one other guy would come in, and then another one would come in, and so on. But I was always there. Because you know, I'm the bottom of the pole. The baby, so to speak. And they had very, very strong personalities those people. I had to sort of like draw from my military experience in order to survive there, my confidence level. Otherwise confidence could have been crushed. You had to be very sure of yourself in the band like that. Everybody was so individualized.

MR: I see. It's amazing that he could hold it together.

JL: Well he would listen and he would put all of this together in composition. He'd listen. Anybody said something, he'd just let it go you know. But there are times he would get the band together and he'd give them a piece of his mind. And everybody was — he'd say some things I'd never heard anybody else say. And he'd walk around and he'd tell each person, this is the way it is. Then he'd go back to his regular self.

MR: What kind of things would he say?

JL: Well I can't mention that on camera, you don't say that kind of stuff. But he would use some words that were not too pleasant.

MR: So every once in a while he had to kind of —

JL: Yeah, he had to straighten everybody out. But most of the time he was just easy going. If he found somebody not pulling their end of the bargain he would feature them a lot. Like Paul used to go to sleep on the stand a lot. He'd always pull Paul out and feature him two or three times in a row.

MR: That's one way to keep them awake.

JL: Right.

MR: Who was the drummer when you joined?

JL: We had several. Sam Woodyard was the first one that I worked with. Then Louie came in. Then there was Rufus Jones, and then there was the other Jones, Elvin Jones was there for a short time. Yeah I was amazed too. And there was another fella that he used, Chris Columbo — not Columbo, it's Columbus. Chris Columbus or Columbo. A fellow out of Atlantic City. Chris, I call him Chris. But he was president of the local there for a while, and he worked with the band for a while. And there were several others that sat in briefly. And it just went on and on. And sometimes we'd have substitutes too. You ever hear of a guy by the name of Dollar Brand?

MR: Yes. Sure.

JL: He had his first gig with Duke.

MR: He's from South Africa isn't he?

JL: Yeah. And there was a guy by the name of Wolf Freeman who was from South Africa, a bass player. He used to come in, he had to come in by way of Canada and then to the United States. And I used to see him out there at Basin Street all the time.

MR: There seemed to be quite a turnover, at least in the drum chair.

JL: Well not really. They were just substitutes. Short term players. It's in this book here. He kept the same people, he had the same saxophone section the whole time I was there.

MR: Right.

JL: I'm sure you are familiar with all of those players.

MR: Sure.

JL: And the same trombone players including Buster Cooper, he lives in town here, he lives in St. Pete. And Chuck Conners and Lawrence Brown. And Cootie and Cat Anderson and sometimes he had Ray Nance and he had Money Johnson sometimes and he had Mercer, who was the business manager as well. There was Herbie Jones. And the weight of the band most of the time was on the drummer and myself as far as keeping time. So I just kept that time.

MR: Right. There was no rhythm guitar.

JL: No.

MR: And Duke didn't always play all that much.

JL: No not all the time, no. And whatever he put up there, I had to be observant enough to catch it, either from his keyboard, from listening to the band, or from reading something that they had written out, they had sketched out something. I had to create a line to that, or if they didn't have the music I had to draw from things I had heard years ago, like the old standards. That's where I learned most of those, just by playing with other groups over a period of time.

MR: Were the veterans in that band, did you have to like prove yourself to them, in their attitude towards you? You were always the newcomer?

JL: Well to some degree. But I was kind of cocky. I knew what I was doing. And what they had to say didn't matter. There was one guy that came over to me once and said, "we'd like to welcome you to the band." Harry Carney. Shook my hand. He says, "enjoy and good luck." And there was one guy one night that said something to me about — something about the rhythm. I says, "well look, I can play your part better than you can. And it's a different instrument. So just go ahead and play your part if you can." That was the end of that. Which I could. I could play his part better than he could. So you had to assert yourself a little bit.

MR: I see. It wasn't the —

JL: In a quiet way.

MR: Yeah. Did you get to witness Duke collaborating with Strayhorn much?

JL: Yeah. I've seen him come in and collaborate, preparing for a television show. They would talk around the piano. And I've seen them talk during recording sessions. Once Billy gave me some music and it was just measures and no notes. No chord changes. "Oh just play what you hear." Yeah. Play what you hear. I've seen that. A lot of times they didn't write anything for the bass.

MR: That seems amazing to me. Because I mean that's where it all starts.

JL: Yeah.

MR: And if you're doing something that, well it certainly can change the sound of the whole thing.

JL: Exactly. Maybe that was his trust that was coming through. Well I mean the band, you know, I have to prove that I'm worthy of being here I guess. So having that bass ear I was able to do that.

MR: Yeah. A couple of the recordings that you did while you were with him, I was curious about, didn't he do one, the music of Mary Poppins?

JL: Yes. That was my first album.

MR: Was that a decision by him to do that music or was that something that would have come from the record company?

JL: Was it for Reprise? Or RC.

MR: I think it was on Reprise.

JL: Yeah that was the Frank Sinatra label, right? At that time.

MR: Yeah.

JL: Well he had to satisfy so many—

MR: Contracts and so forth.

JL: So many a year I suppose. Sure. So he did it in his way. And Billy says, "play this way," I guess you call it a shake. Or he says, "ponticelli," I'm not certain what the term is now I'd have to look it up it's been so long. At the introduction.

MR: Tremolo maybe?

JL: Yeah, something like that.

MR: Okay.

JL: And he says, "play it this way." And that's how that happened. And then there were other spots where he didn't — he'd just have sketches or outlines of majors, sometimes he'd have a note here. So what you hear was the first album that I did. It was done in Chicago at Universal Studios. That kind of collaboration and Billy would tell me, he says — sometimes he'd play piano with us — and he says, "keep playing those low E's. I want to hear that bottom." And I had learned that the bottom. And I had learned that the bottom of the bass is where it is. After all, you are a bass player. In a group like that somebody has to play the foundation. And I notice that today a lot of cats are sort of like infatuated with the upper register. It sounds good. But somebody has to play the bass. Otherwise you have a group without a bass. And that's an area that hasn't been fully explored, that part of the instrument but that's not the only part of the instrument. And there's nothing like having — as a matter of fact it's more difficult to play the lower notes than it is to play the higher notes. I mean to get a rich bottom, a nice, firm bass quality sound.

MR: When Louis Bellson joined the group, was there any kind of problem with him being white?

JL: No there ain't no problem with Louis.

MR: No, no problem with Louis. Oh I know that.

JL: And I didn't see any problems at all.

MR: Okay that's good.

JL: Yeah, Louis is a sweetheart. And Paul was a sweetheart. Yeah. Everybody loved those guys.

MR: Yeah?

JL: Yeah. All those guys, each one had their own characteristics and each one I learned to appreciate them for what they were and what they had to offer and who they were. Sure. And they were all unique. If you understood that, and I think that's what apparently Duke understood each person. And you could put all this together and all of this comes through his love and understanding.

MR: Yeah.

JL: Yeah.

MR: What was it like going overseas with the group?

JL: Well after I told Mercer, I says well I don't care for this, I think I'll go back to Philly. It's not what I thought it was.

MR: How long were you in the band?

JL: Oh two or three months. Or maybe a month or so. I said I don't care for this. Well Mercer says, "why don't you go overseas first, then make your decision." He says, "we're going over around January or February or something like that." So okay, I hung in there and we went overseas. And I discovered that the audiences were much different. That made an impression. They were quite receptive to Duke's band. And I noticed that when I went to England, there I was, my picture was in the program, not a picture but a statement. They say "this young man reminds us of the great Jimmy Blanton in his sound." I said hmmm. Looks good. And then at another place in France they had my picture on the front page. We were artists. We weren't somebody just playing a instrument. And the people showed it. There was one fellow that I met that asked to carry my bass who was a cabby, asked if he would take it to the concert hall. He took the instrument, put it on top of his cab, tied it down, he called me sir. An entirely different thing then I had experienced over here earlier you know. And I hopped in. He closed the door, walked in, and I gave him a nice tip I hope, because it was foreign exchange. And the people were always so, so warm and receptive. I guess that's what it meant at that time to be a celebrity or with Duke Ellington. Then when we got back over here I took a bus, a city bus, with the bass, hopped on the bus and the driver says, "where are you going with that thing?" Well I'm going to the city you know. But I'm showing a difference in the attitude.

MR: Yeah. Welcome home.

JL: Yeah. We were well received there. We were received over here by fans, all the fans of Duke loved Duke. But those that didn't understand the music or didn't have anything to do with it, we were just, you know, in my opinion.

MR: The years you were with him were pretty intense times for civil rights. Did that movement affect Ellington at all, or the operations of the band?

JL: Well I don't think it affected Ellington in his attitudes but I'm sure he had some thoughts about it because he had thoughts about everything. But we did run into a few riots. One, the one in L.A., we were playing at Disneyland and a riot broke out that night and they wouldn't let us back to our places. We couldn't get back there. Isn't that amazing? We couldn't go through certain sections of town. Things were burning. And once we were outside of Detroit and a similar thing happened. They wouldn't let us in town. Mercer made the announcement. "They says we can't stay in town tonight fellas, we'll have to stay on the outskirts." And once in Milwaukee we went in with an armed guard I believe, they escorted us through the thing there. They were having some problems. Those are the three cases that I remember.

MR: Did the fellows in that band have like — I don't know if this is the right word — but did they have any hobbies that helped them get through all that time they spent on a bus or just on the road?

JL: Oh yes. Herbie Jones was a photographer. He took pictures of guys in the band. And some guys would walk. And some guys would cook. Johnny Hodges did that, he used to cook. And some were just — just enjoyed each new town as they came to it. But they had their little hobbies. But you usually, after a night on the bus you are tired. You have time to eat and then make the next concert and go to the next gig.

MR: One after the other.

JL: Yes.

MR: Did it get hard with your family situation?

JL: Oh yes. It was hard. I'll never forget the look on my wife's face the night that I went on the road. I wish I could take that face and just transform it into something else, but it was a look — a true sense of separation. But we received a lot of encouragement from people that had been on the road for a while. The wives. The people like Mrs. Reed, she encouraged us quite a bit. And she kept in contact with my wife. And she said the sound is important. And a guy sat on the bus one day and he says, "hey John, don't play this thing cheaply," he says, "this is going to be very important one of these days." He says, "I know how you feel but it's important. People love this guy." He was one of the copyists for the band. He went through his headaches trying to copy Duke's music. Because he didn't copy for each instrument, he copied for individuals. He'd have the

lines all crossed and he'd have to siphon through all these lines. And he understood, you know, the techniques. Herbie Jones was the copyist.

MR: Yeah, that must have been a chore.

JL: Sure, he wrote his lines for each person. And it all came out — it sounded distorted to them but to Duke, that's what he wanted. And he always found a way to incorporate each new personality into the band.

MR: Well, since those years you've remained, made your living as a musician and how did you end up back in Florida?

JL: Well we were reading a series of articles about life in Sarasota. And I had attended the college and I had been there five years and I had gotten my double degree and I taught in Philly for a couple of years in the prep department at the school as well as Ripple School. So we hopped in the car and we drove down to Sarasota and Miami and all those places. And we checked the places out. We decided that Sarasota was not it for us, so we came back up to St. Petersburg and discovered that that's where Buster Cooper lived, my old road buddy. And we says well Buster lives here, and this is centrally located, Tampa is here, Clearwater is here, Sarasota is here, this is the place to be. So we decided on St. Petersburg. And on top of that I wanted my kids to grow up with the proper attitude. I didn't want them to have to fight their way to school and back, you know, in the inner city, like a lot a problems can happen like that with other kids and groups and that type of thing.

MR: How many kids did you have?

JL: Two. And so that's how we ended up down here. The kids, plus I had the ability to teach now, I've had the license to teach, so I came down and went into the insurance business for a year, and they says, "are you crazy?" Well I could still play a little bit, and then I decided after a year that that wasn't for me, and decided that I would get into the orchestra. So I played with the orchestra, the Tampa Bay Orchestra. And my wife and kids were there the first night, opening night. But I soon discovered that wasn't for me because we'd rehearse and rehearse and rehearse the same thing over and over again, and then the conductor would go crazy sometimes, and all for $25, you know what I mean, for a rehearsal. And I discovered I could come back over to the hotel and make maybe $250 a week or so and just have a great time. So I did that. And also during that time I played with the Opera House here for about two or three years, got that little experience under my belt. And in the meantime I got this gig teaching high school. I taught high school, and when that came along I got a job teaching at the junior college. The word began to get around. And I began to teach the different schools, and then I went to middle school and stayed there over 20 years, and I retired after 25 years in a middle school, 27 years all total teaching.

MR: Were you teaching music?

JL: I was teaching music and math.

MR: And math.

JL: And language arts.

MR: I'll be darned.

JL: And social studies. Then while I was in this math thing I became re-certified. I went to the JC and picked up what, 16 credits, and immediately after that was done they took me out of math and put me back into music. So I became a choral director, and a band director. And then I decided that that was the end of it. But during all of this time I had continued to play on weekends and nights. And one year they had a jazz policy, where I worked six nights a week. All the jazz artists came in, oh guys that were on the road. For one year, it was at Tierverdi Island Resort I believe it's called. We played there for all the greats, with a trio. It was called the John Lamb Trio and we went to do revues every week and we had a great time with that.

MR: Wow. You've had an amazing life.

JL: Well I would say that it's great, wonderful. And it's still amazing. It seems to be getting bigger and bigger. It doesn't end. And all I did was, at the time when I was looking for employment I was trying to survive. And I'll tell you one thing. This thing about becoming the world's greatest bass player. One night I was on stage with Barney Briggs — Bunny.

MR: Bunny Berigan?

JL: No, the tap dancer.

MR: Oh yeah.

JL: Bunny.

MR: Briggs.

JL: And then we were playing and he was dancing, and then he went up to the mic and he says, "ladies and gentlemen, I'd like to introduce you to the world's greatest bass player." I said to myself I made it. Isn't that something?

MR: That's excellent.

JL: Just one person said that. And I said I made it. Yeah.

MR: Wow. Congratulations.

JL: Of course you and I realize there is no such thing, everybody has a way of expressing themselves, it's just different. And it depends on personal taste. A note is a note.

MR: Well I really want to thank you for your time. We chatted for quite a long time here. What do you think of the state of jazz today?

JL: Oh man it's blooming all over the place. Blossoming. I love what I see. I mean you go on the Internet and you can get anything that you want. It's all there. It's beautiful. And

more concerts, more everything. I have more gigs than I can handle. Don't tell the guys up north now.

MR: Right. That's right. We don't them all coming down here, right?

JL: But you see, speaking of that, I had a choice between going — I could have gone anywhere. I could have gone to L.A. to try to do the studios thing, I could have gone to New York or gone anywhere. But I chose to come to a little place like St. Petersburg. And it has blossomed into a big thing. It's like the old story about the mountain coming to Muhammad. That's what happened. All you need is the concept, and work long and hard enough. Persistence. You don't necessarily need a great deal of talent but you need the drive. The energy to get you where you'd like to go.

MR: Well said. Well thanks for your time today.

JL: Well thank you very much, my pleasure.

MR: It's been really fascinating.